HONOR CHOICE Earbuds X5

Value-rich but sound needs refinement

HONOR is starting its journey to make a mark in the AIOT landscape in India with the debut of the HONOR CHOICE Earbuds X5 and the HONOR CHOICE Watch. These new releases coincide with the introduction of the latest HONOR X9B smartphone to the Indian market by HTech. I got the HONOR CHOICE Earbuds X5 for review and was immediately intrigued since this is the first pair of HONOR earbuds I've tested.

The HONOR CHOICE Earbuds X5 boasts a range of appealing features despite its budget-friendly positioning. Notably, it offers Active Noise Cancellation, app integration, Low Latency Mode, and IP54 dust and splash resistance. Yet, in a highly competitive budget TWS market in India, standing out is crucial amidst strong contenders like OnePlus, Realme, boAt, Boult Audio, and Noise. Throughout this review, I'll delve into aspects ranging from design and comfort to performance and battery life, with a particular focus on its comparison to the OnePlus Nord Buds 2, given their similar features and sub-₹3,000 price range.

₹2,449

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BUILD, DESIGN, AND FIT

The HONOR CHOICE Earbuds X5 is no looker. It has a drab look with pretty much no visual flair. The case is as plain as one can be, borrowing design aspects from the AirPods. It is a glossy white case that can get scratched pretty easily if you're not super careful. There's an LED battery indicator and a USB-C charging port on the outside, and that's about it.

Where it does shine is pocketability. The pebble-shaped case is easily portable and can be slipped into small pockets or purses. It is also exceedingly easy to open one-handed. However, the hinge is pretty flimsy and the construction of the entire case feels rather cheap in comparison to the OnePlus Nord Buds 2 and even the cheaper Nord Buds 2r.

The same applies to the earbuds – they look plain and feel flimsy. However, they are pretty lightweight and the fit is not bad, so it's quite comfortable to wear them. The earbuds also come equipped with touch controls that work surprisingly well. You also get IP54 dust and splash resistance on the earbuds to protect them from damage.

All in all, the HONOR CHOICE Earbuds X5 will not turn any heads, but they are pretty functional in the way they are designed.

FEATURES

The HONOR CHOICE Earbuds X5 is one of the most feature-rich truly wireless earbuds you can get your hands on under ₹3,000. HONOR has hit the nail on its head when it comes to packing these buds with an array of nifty features.

First off, the earbuds come with Active Noise Cancellation up to 30 dB. The ANC works shockingly well for the price; sounds such as the low drone of an air conditioner are immediately silenced. However, if you use these in traffic with high-pitched horns, they won't be able to drown those out. Still, it is decent ANC for the price. There's also an Awareness Mode that bolsters the sounds around you when you want to be aware of your surroundings.

The HONOR CHOICE Earbuds X5 also has an excellent companion app. It has all the features I consider to be essential at this price point. You can check your earbuds' battery level, toggle Active Noise Cancellation on or off, pick between EQ profiles, customise touch controls, and update the firmware. The only thing missing is a customisable EQ, but then again, given the competitive pricing, that can be forgiven.

You also get a Low Latency Game Mode that worked decently well in my testing; there was no perceivable lag between audio and video, which is great. The earbuds do not have on-ear detection, which is slightly disappointing.

PERFORMANCE

The HONOR CHOICE Earbuds X5 house 10 mm drivers and support the SBC and AAC audio codecs. The sound quality requires some tuning, in my opinion though. The earbuds have a very dark sound profile with a muddy, overbearing bass response that dilutes the intricacies of the instruments and vocals that lie in the mid-range. There's some serious auditory masking in the mids and low-highs, which is a shame.

I tested the HONOR CHOICE Earbuds X5 on our testing rig and the frequency